

EITC Eligibility Checklist + 4 Other Tax Credits

The Earned Income Tax Credit (EITC) is refundable — meaning you get CASH even if you owe \$0 in tax. 1 in 5 people who qualify never claim it. Here's how to know if you're one of them, plus 4 other credits people leave behind.

✓ EITC Quick Eligibility Check

- ☐ You (or your spouse) worked or had self-employment / gig income last year (earned income)
- ☐ Your total income is under the limit for your filing status and number of qualifying children (see table below)
- ☐ Investment income under ~\$12,000
- ☐ You and any children have valid Social Security numbers
- ☐ You're not claimed as someone else's dependent
- ☐ **No kids?** You must be age 25–64 (with kids, no age limit for the credit itself)

EITC 2026 Income Limits & Max Credit

Qualifying Children	Max Credit	Income Limit (Single)	Income Limit (Married Filing Jointly)
0 children	~\$660	~\$19,000–\$26,000	~\$25,000–\$32,000
1 child	~\$4,400	~\$50,000	~\$56,000
2 children	~\$7,300	~\$56,000	~\$62,000
3+ children	~\$8,200	~\$60,000	~\$66,000

Numbers are approximate for 2026 (adjusted annually for inflation). Check the official IRS EITC Assistant for your exact situation.

The 3-Year Rule: If you qualified in a past year and didn't claim it, you can usually go back 3 years and file an amended return (Form 1040-X) to collect the money NOW. That can be several thousand dollars stacked up, just waiting.

How to Claim EITC (Free)

- ☐ **Step 1:** Run the official **IRS EITC Assistant** to check your eligibility (takes ~5 mins): [irs.gov](#) (search "EITC Assistant")
- ☐ **Step 2:** File your tax return. If your income qualifies for EITC, you almost certainly qualify to **file for FREE**:
 - ☐ **IRS Free File:** income under ~\$84,000 → [irs.gov/filing/free-file](#)
 - ☐ **VITA (Volunteer Income Tax Assistance):** income under ~\$67,000, free in-person help → [irs.treasury.gov/freetaxprep](#)
 - ☐ **IRS Direct File:** available in some states → [irs.gov/directfile](#)
- ☐ **Step 3:** To claim past years, file an **amended return (Form 1040-X)** for each year you missed.

State EITC Bonus: 30+ states have their own Earned Income Credit stacked on top of the federal one (usually a % of your federal credit, often refundable). Check your state's tax agency website — it can add hundreds more to your refund!

3 Costly EITC Mistakes — Don't Make Them

- ☐ **Mistake 1:** "I don't earn enough to file." **WRONG.** With a refundable credit, low income is the qualifier, not the disqualifier. No return = \$0 refund.
- ☐ **Mistake 2:** Filing-status or qualifying-child errors. Child must meet age, relationship, and residency tests (generally living with you more than half the year). Get this wrong and IRS can delay or deny the whole thing.

☐ **Mistake 3:** Only looking at this year, never checking the prior 3 years — where the biggest stacked refunds hide.

+ 4 Other Tax Credits You Might Be Missing

1. Saver's Credit (Retirement Savings Contribution Credit)

Up to \$1,000 (\$2,000 for couples)

Put money into a 401(k) or IRA + modest income = credit. Not refundable (lowers tax owed), but can wipe out what you owe.

2. Child Tax Credit (+ Additional Child Tax Credit)

Up to \$2,200 per child under 17 (up to \$1,700 refundable)

The Additional Child Tax Credit portion is refundable = cash even with little tax owed.

3. American Opportunity Tax Credit (College)

Up to \$2,500 per student (up to \$1,000 refundable)

First 4 years of higher ed. Even low-income students/parents can get cash back.

4. Premium Tax Credit (Health Insurance Marketplace)

Can be substantial (depends on income & plan)

Buy insurance through ACA marketplace = refundable credit. **Heads up:** enhanced subsidies expired end of 2025, so 2026 help is smaller — check current marketplace numbers.

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General educational information, not tax or financial advice. Tax rules and dollar limits change every year — always check current IRS guidance at [irs.gov](https://www.irs.gov) or consult a qualified tax professional for your specific situation.